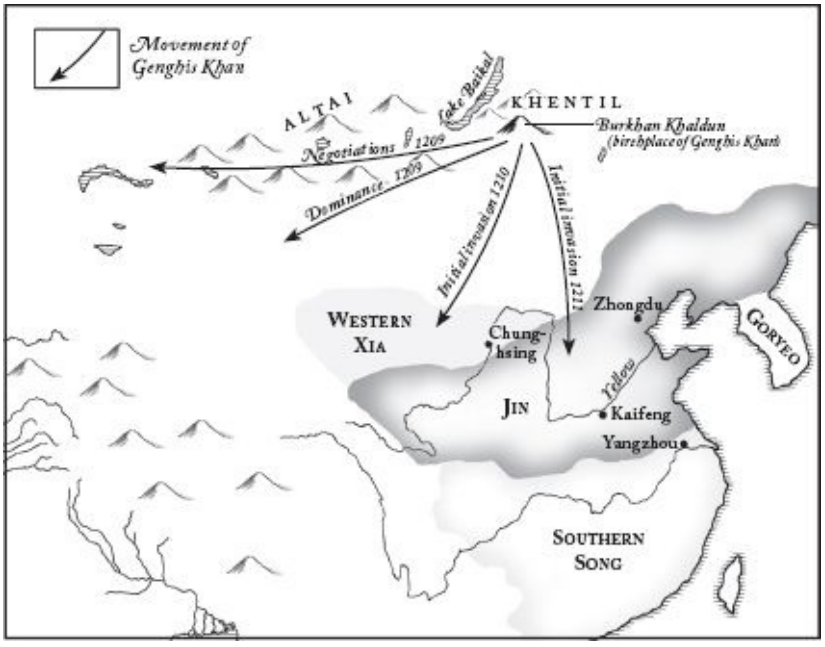
1201 and 1204, the Mongol tribes divided into two factions behind the two leaders.

But through a combination of persuasion and conquest, Temujin's following swelled while Jamuqa's shrank away. When Temujin's old ally Toghrul hesitated, unsure which man to join, Temujin attacked the Kerait tribe and forced it to submit. Toghrul fled westward, into the territory of the Naiman tribe, where he was accidentally killed by a border guard. Outnumbered and outmanned, Jamuqa followed him.

In 1204, Temujin pursued his old friend into Naiman territory and wiped out the men who had given Jamuqa shelter: "[He] utterly defeated and conquered the people of the Naiman tribe on the southern slopes of the Altai," says *The Secret History*. Jamuqa escaped into the mountains and lived there as an outcast until he was finally taken prisoner by Temujin's men.

Brought before Temujin, he asked one last favor from his childhood companion: "Let me die swiftly," he said, "and your heart will be at rest. And . . . let them kill me without shedding blood." To die without bloodshed was the privilege of an honorable warrior, and Temujin granted the request. As Jamuqa left his presence, two guards broke the prisoner's back.[5]

Now Temujin was without rival; all he had to do was return to the Mongol heartland, to the foot of Burkhan Khaldun, and claim the title Great Khan. But before he turned back east, he sent his lieutenant, Ilah Ahai, on an exploratory raid into the nearby kingdom of the Western Xia.*



27.1 The Advance of the Mongols